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SOUTH INDIAN FILM INDUSTRY

THE SOUTH SURGES AHEAD

As Bollywood faltered, southern cinema stepped up to fill the void, regaling audiences in the Hindi belt...and even in the US

By Suhani Singh









SOUTHERN TSUNAMI (Clockwise from above) Stills from *KGF: Chapter 2*, *Ponniyin Selvan*, *RRR* and *Kantara*

The year 2022 saw Hindi cinema, a.k.a. Bollywood, further lose its grip on the masses. Capitalising on this lull, the southern film industry stepped up to regale audiences, even those in the Hindi belt. At the forefront was Yash-starrer *KGF: Chapter 2*, the highest-grossing film of 2022 in India and also the second biggest in the history of Indian cinema. The Kannada actor personified the rage, swagger and machismo that made his Rocky Bhai an icon for the working class, much like Amitabh Bachchan's Vijay. Yash's biggest achievement though was putting the relatively smaller Kannada film industry on the national map. Five months later, *Kantara*, featuring Rishab Shetty as a rebel protecting his village, became a nationwide hit, introducing audiences to the captivating *buta kola* tradition of coastal Karnataka.

Visionary Telugu filmmaker S.S. Rajamouli delivered yet another blockbuster, *RRR: Rise Roar Revolt*, which—though not matching the colossal collections of his last film, *Baahubali 2*—went far beyond in raising his credentials. Ever since its Hindi-dubbed version released on Netflix, Hollywood has championed Rajamouli for his ingenious action sequences and big-screen cinematic fervour. After *RRR* failed to become India's official entry for the Best International Film at the Oscars, Rajamouli and his team soldiered on, launching an independent campaign that resulted in '*Naatu Naatu*' making it to the shortlist of the Best Song category.

Six of the 10 highest-grossing Indian films of 2022 came from the South

That wasn't all. Mani Ratnam, one of Indian cinema's most respected filmmakers, demonstrated that he can deliver both an engaging action epic and a riveting political drama with *Ponniyin Selvan: I*—Tamil cinema's biggest blockbuster. Veteran Kamal Haasan, too, enjoyed his career's biggest hit with action drama *Vikram*, which also featured Vijay Sethupathi and Fahadh Faasil, two powerhouse performers gradually expanding their fandom beyond the south. One of Hindi cinema's biggest films in 2022, *Drishyam 2*, was also a remake of a Malayalam hit. Instead of resorting to remakes, perhaps it's time Bollywood filmmakers sought inspiration from their southern colleagues to tell rooted stories with universal appeal. ■